

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

The following are Matt's answers to commonly asked interview questions

General & Cultural Fit

1. How do you handle uncertainty and rapid changes in a project?
 1. I handle change and uncertainty exceptionally well - nearly every company that I've ever worked at has been a startup in a fast-moving industry, so I'm used to rapid change and I am comfortable with the reality that projects rarely finish on time and typically hit a number of unforeseen obstacles. In order to mitigate these challenges, I try to budget extra time and/or resources, and when things do inevitably change, I believe that it's crucial to first notify everyone on the project who is immediately impacted, and then triage concerns and address them in order of impact to get the project back on track.
2. Describe a situation where you had to wear multiple hats or go beyond your defined role. How did you handle it?
 1. When I was a Sr Account Manager at Flow Kana, I was called upon multiple times to conduct market research for our new concentrate line called Caldera and present it to the production team. That was never in my actual job description, but since I was in the field talking to customers and account key holders I had the best vantage point from which to observe changes in the competitive landscape. I enjoyed the project, particularly because I already had specific ideas that I wanted the product team to approve and incorporate, so I ran my competitive analysis, it helped inform the product which turned out well in the first iteration, which is pretty rare.
3. What's your biggest failure, and what did you learn from it?
 1. My biggest failure was also at Flow Kana, and it was with a large dispensary client. The client had run up a large bill with my company, and I was paid commission on it. Unfortunately, the client had much longer payment terms than I thought, and it turned out that I'd overlooked that detail. I got paid out on my commissions before my company got paid, and it almost ruined my relationship with my manager and the account. If there's one thing that I learned from that experience, it is to always take your time, read everything multiple times, and make sure to double check your math!
4. How do you prioritize tasks when you have multiple competing deadlines?
 1. I try to put myself in future-Matt's shoes and think "In which situation will the consequences be the worse if I miss the deadline?", and then prioritize based on that. Additionally, I'll always communicate with my team members and stakeholders to see if there is any flexibility and try to work out a mutually-agreeable situation where the truly dire projects are prioritized.

Problem-Solving & Analytical Thinking

5. Tell me about a time when you had to solve a problem with limited resources or time.
 1. I've been in a massive number of situations with strict parameters, but some of the ones that stick out in my mind as being the most stressful always involved getting deliveries to customers when I was working in Cannabis as an Account Manager. A key component of that job was making sure that our customers always had product on the shelf, and there were many situations where there was some mistake in fulfillment that required me to drive the order there myself, pick up a large amount of cash payment myself, or get the product from the store and drive it back to the distributor. Overall, my solution in most situations with limited resources is to simply take on the burden myself, or if I can't, come to a compromise that buys me enough time to put the money or team together. I've rarely come up against instances like this which are truly impossible to navigate, and many times simply

asking the involved parties for more time or resources, ensuring them that the job will be done ASAP and to the highest standard, ameliorates the situation.

6. How do you approach debugging an issue when you have limited information?
 1. If there is limited information available and none more can be obtained, that is often a situation where I will look for help, either on the internet or through a colleague or expert, and if I come up empty-handed there, my next step would be to find a workaround in the meantime so the product continues to work while I take extra time to resolve the original issue.
7. If you had only 24 hours to deliver a project, what would be your process?
 1. Determine the goal of the project with respect to the business and which is most important to leadership
 2. (Assuming that this is the kind of project that would typically take much longer to complete) Determine which aspects of the project should take precedence given the goal
 3. Identify any contingencies
 4. Prioritize contingencies and components that will require downtime (if there are any)
 5. Ensure first that the project is complete at the most minimally viable level, and then if there are any time/resources that remain, shore up critical aspects
8. Explain a complex problem you solved recently. How did you approach it?
 1. I recently built a RAG application, which uses a Large Language Model to query a document which is loaded into a database. It was my first Gen AI project and there were a number of technical snags that I hit in the process of getting it to work. One of my favorite things about programming and technical disciplines, however, is that there is always a solution, and I have faith in my research skills to find it. I approach solving problems methodically at first, breaking apart major issues into smaller components that can be addressed more easily independently. There were, however, a few instances that required me to delve more deeply into the documentation for Langchain, Streamlit, Llamaparse, and some other frameworks that I used to more completely understand what was going on under the hood. In almost every case I used resources like Github and Stackoverflow, and also YouTube tutorials, and medium articles. Over the course of solving this problem I learned a ton about LLMs and Langchain specifically, which is an incredibly powerful tool that I've immensely enjoyed learning how to use.
9. Describe a time when you had to pivot from an initial idea or solution. How did you adapt?
 1. I have pivoted numerous times in my life, so I'll just list them out here:
 1. Transferring universities from Babson College to Santa Clara University after my sophomore year. I made this change because after the financial crisis of 2008 I decided to abandon my plans to go into banking
 2. When I decided to leave tech in 2015 and pursue a career in the Cannabis industry. It was a lengthy adaptation process, and involved, among other things, completely conquering my fear of rejection as several jobs that I took in the industry required strong sales skills
 3. After Garden Society laid me off in February, I had to pivot once again, and once again the adaptation process has been lengthy. I'm still in the middle of it, in fact!

Technical Skills

10. Can you walk me through your most challenging technical project? What were the key obstacles?
11. Describe a time when you had to learn a new technology quickly. How did you go about it?
 1. In the process of building a RAG system as my first chatbot project, I had to learn Langchain, which is an incredibly powerful tool but also complex and not yet 100% stable. Fortunately, the documentation is quite helpful. Additionally, the tutorials that the Langchain team published in conjunction with DeepLearning.ai helped me

gain a better grasp of the framework conceptually. When it comes to building A.I. chatbots, I personally like to set them up in a Jupyter Notebook so I can troubleshoot more easily.

Team Collaboration

12. Describe a time when you had a disagreement with a teammate. How did you resolve it?
 1. When I was working at Flow Kana, I had a bit of a struggle working with the fulfillment team (the group that packed up and delivered the orders that I submitted), because they didn't initially understand that there was a sense of urgency, and I didn't understand some crucial
13. How do you give and receive feedback in a small team setting?
 1. Always be solution oriented
 2. Ask qualifying questions
 3. Praise in public, criticize in private
 4. Give credit where credit is due
14. How do you handle working with non-technical stakeholders?
 1. Analogies
 2. Patience

Soft skills that I can bring to any team:

- **Client services experience:** I've spent nearly my entire professional life in externally-facing roles that required good communication skills, relationship building, an innate understanding of how to solve problems for people and give them a good experience. I believe that the fundamental basis for client services / account management is ensuring that the customer's experience with your company is a good one, even when things go wrong. This amounts to pre-empting problems, understanding your clients' preferred work styles, being able to 'read the room', respecting people's time, being able to find common ground, being timely and proactive in your communication, asking the right questions, and most importantly of all, being a good listener. Over the course of my life, I've been able to deal amiably and effectively with all different types of personalities, from engineers to ex-drug dealers, and everything in between. I believe that people desperately want to be heard, and to feel like they matter, so that is the approach that I bring to any interaction, professional or personal.
- **Resilience:** For someone that hasn't fought in a war, I've been through a lot. I've moved a lot during my life, I've successfully repaired many relationships, I've had many jobs, struggled through many physical injuries. traveled far and wide, played contact sports, and most of all, I can deal with insults and difficult personalities very well. It really takes a lot to get under my skin, and it takes a lot to make me truly angry. I've never lost my temper in a professional situation, and I rarely lose my temper in my personal life. I believe that any problem can be solved, and any negative situation can be turned into a positive one. Most importantly of all, I know how to bite my tongue in a tense situation.
- **Strong negotiating skills:** In my past jobs, particularly in the cannabis industry, I've been able to strike many mutually beneficial deals, particularly in the following scenario: Flow Kana in 2018 had a difficult problem to solve - getting dispensary buyers and their customers to pay higher prices for bespoke, sustainably produced outdoor cannabis strains that, according to the industry orthodoxy, should be priced lower (indoor flower was better than outdoor flower because it cost more to produce, had a lighter color, often had a higher THC (tetrahydrocannabinol) percentage, and was more aesthetically pleasing due to the higher coverage of trichome crystals). This was the greatest challenge at Flow Kana, and I had many long conversations with dispensary buyers where I extolled the values of a sustainable supply chain, presented the product in a different, more positive light, and through patient and respectful conversation, and a lot of listening, I was able to convince many of them that Flow Kana's product was worth the price, and as a result the company grew to be the largest cannabis flower brand in California for 25 months consecutively.

- **Strong problem solving** :For as long as I can remember, I've been a natural problem solver. I've never been one to just let things remain in an unsatisfactory state for long when I had the means and the impetus to improve them. As a result, I've been successful in every job that I've had that has involved problem solving, particularly when they are open-ended. An example of this in my early career, part of the first 5 years that I spent in tech, was at Milestone. It became clear to me and my manager that I really excelled at and enjoyed onboarding a new client, which entailed having many conversations regarding their business goals, their understanding of internet marketing, pitching them on different products and services, getting to know them personally, and setting up their account for success at the company. As a result I got to work with some really fun resort clients, flew out to meet them, and got to know them and their business intimately. It was a process that worked incredibly well, and it taught me that I enjoyed the sales process as much as I enjoyed the post-sales, account management process.
- **Self-teaching:** I've taught myself a wide variety of skills, including playing the guitar, music production, programming in the python language, physical fitness, weightlifting, cooking, public speaking, and field sales skills. In fact, the vast majority of things that I currently know how to do were not taught to me, but rather I had to learn them on the fly.
- **Strong research skills**
- **Ability to find common ground with pretty much any type of person.**
- **Entrepreneurial:** I've always been a self-starter. I've started multiple bands/music projects, I started a tech startup in the cannabis space, I'm frequently the one to plan group trips and adventures, and most recently I started a chatbot development agency.
- **Strong Organizational Skills**
- **Sales re: rejection:** My work in field sales in the cannabis industry helped me eradicate any lingering fear of rejection that I had going into my late 20's. As a result, I'm comfortable delivering a product pitch or presentation, and I can drive meetings effectively.
- **Attention to detail:** Writing invoices for cannabis businesses was a delicate endeavor, as one small mistake could create an enormous amount of work for several teams of people.
- **Able to drive projects forward:** At my core I am a results-oriented person. I deeply enjoy the feeling of making progress, and while I will let myself digress into the procrastination-perfectionism loop, it is not difficult for me to call a project done and move forward.
- **Hard Technical skills:**
 - - Data analysis
 - - Machine Learning model development
 - - Generative A.I. chatbot development
- **Strongest personality characteristics:**
 - - Creative problem solving
 - - Great communication skills
 - - Follow through
- **Weakest personality characteristics**
 - - Impatience
- **What lessons did you take away from your experience in the cannabis industry:**
 - Don't pop the champagne too soon (don't celebrate big wins until the deal is 100% done)
 - Don't overspend on infrastructure
 - Protect your supply chain at all costs
 - People will go to great lengths to avoid paying their bills
 - Everyone appreciates timely follow up
 - People love to be listened to

- If you are passionate about the product that your company makes, work becomes much more fulfilling
- Avoid prioritizing short term gain unless there is an incredibly good reason for it
- **How do you work best?**
 - I work very well in small groups where there is a high degree of autonomy. Deadlines are very helpful to me, as are regular check ins with my manager and leadership.
- **What do you think about the future of A.I.?**
 - The current progress in the field of A.I. appears to me as if we are recreating the human brain one cell at a time. With every new fine tuned model we filling in a map, one square at a time. I personally am in favor of increased A.I. development, for the following reasons":
 - There are some incredibly pressing, complex problems critical to the survival of both the human race and the planet which appear to have outstripped human capacity to reason through, including environmental degradation, climate change, healthcare, and global economics.
 - At no point in human history has attempting to halt the train of technological progress yielded good results.
 - Over-regulating A.I. will only push it underground
 - I do believe that AGI could potentially lead to a form of techno-utopia, but if it does, there will be a very painful readjusting period for all of humanity.
- **What are your thoughts on remote work?**
 - I believe that prioritizing remote work for as many people as it can reasonably apply to, will fix several problems - urban planning, mental health, housing, and productivity. Commuting is a massive financial and mental strain on people and companies that afford their employees with the ability to save time and money by working remotely will inevitably have access to better and more loyal talent in the long run.
- **Elaborate on being a hybrid worker with account management + technical experience:**
 - I have a unique blend of experience that I'm proud to have cultivated as a result of my life decisions to continue trying new things. I know that this will make me a valuable team player at any company in a future dominated by A.I., because I have
 - 1) The ability to learn new skills quickly
 - 2) Strong soft skills and the ability to work seamlessly with a wide variety of people
 - 3) A technical understanding of A.I. app development gained through actually building several chatbots, RAG pipelines, and machine learning algorithms.
 - It's no secret that technical skills and sales skills do not significantly overlap in many people. I am proud to say that I have tested myself against the world in a variety of ways, through work, through self-imposed change, through learning new skills, and I have found that I am equally adept at working with people as I am working with things.